The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: AFP via Getty Images

Late on Saturday **Donald Trump** said Iran had 48 hours to fully open the **Strait of Hormuz** or America would "obliterate" its power plants. Earlier America's Central Command said Iran's ability to threaten marine traffic in the strait had been "degraded" as a result of bombing attacks. On Friday Mr Trump said he was considering "winding down" the war.

Dozens of people were injured in two **Iranian** missile attacks on southern **Israel**. One of the strikes hit Dimona, a city near the country's main nuclear facility; the other struck the town of Arad. Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, said it had been a "difficult" night and that Israel would keep up its attacks on Iran.

Japan's foreign minister suggested that his country's armed forces could be sent to the **Strait of Hormuz** for minesweeping operations "if there were to be a complete ceasefire". Japan gets about 70% of its oil in shipments through the strait. Together with other Asian countries such as China and India, it has been negotiating with Iran to let its vessels through.

Polls opened in **France** for mayoral elections, the last big ballot before next year's presidential elections. The most important contest is in Paris, where Rachida Dati, the centre-right candidate,

has a good chance of ending 25 years of Socialist rule. The national performance of the populist-left party, Unsubmissive France, will be watched closely too.

Robert Mueller, a former director of the FBI, died aged 81. He led a federal investigation into allegations of collusion between the Trump campaign and Russia in the lead-up to America's presidential election in 2016. Responding to the news, Mr Trump wrote on Truth Social, his social-media site, that he was "glad" Mueller was dead.

Mr Trump threatened to deploy Immigration and Customs Enforcement agents to airports if congressional Democrats do not agree to fund airport security. The president wrote on social media that **ICE agents** would "do Security like no one has ever seen before". A partial government shutdown means that the Transportation Security Administration personnel who are ordinarily responsible for airport security could soon miss a second pay cheque.

The Trump administration filed a lawsuit against **Harvard University** for allegedly failing to deal with antisemitism and discrimination against **Jewish and Israeli students**. The suit seeks to stop paying existing grants to Harvard, and demands it pay restitution for any made since at least October 7th 2023. A Harvard spokesman said the university has taken "substantive, proactive steps" to deal with the issues.

Word of the week: Chinamaxxing, a social media trend whereby young Westerners adopt Chinese habits like drinking hot water or Tsingtao beer. Read our report on increasingly favourable views of China in the west, and why the feeling is not mutual.

Photograph: Reuters

A big moment for Germany's social democrats

The election for state premier in Rhineland-Palatinate on Sunday will be a nip-and-tuck race between Alexander Schweitzer, the incumbent, and Gordon Schnieder, from the centre-right Christian Democratic Union. He has a good chance to topple Mr Schweitzer, whose Social Democratic Party (SPD) has been in power for 35 years.

Even if Mr Schweitzer loses, the new state government is likely to be a grand coalition between his centre-left party and the CDU. Neither would govern with the populist-right Alternative for Germany, which is forecast to double its share of the vote to 19% since the last election in 2019.

Rhineland-Palatinate is the second of five German states to vote this year. Earlier this month the SPD received only 5.5% in Baden-Württemberg, its worst post-war result ever. Losing Rhineland-Palatinate would be another huge blow for the old workers' party. It once boasted more than 40% of the votes in federal elections. Now it lingers at only 14% in the polls.

Photograph: Reuters

Giorgia Meloni’s risky referendum

Ostensibly, a referendum in Italy on Sunday and Monday is about judicial reform. In fact, it has largely become a test of the popularity of Giorgia Meloni’s right-wing government. The legislation at stake is of little interest to the public: the separation of prosecutors and judges (they can currently switch between the two careers, though few do) and the random selection of some members of the watchdog bodies proposed for each profession. Opposition parties have depicted the reform, backed by Ms Meloni, as a sly attempt to undermine Italy’s constitution. But Italy’s prosecutors would still be far freer than their French and German counterparts, who are directly subordinated to government ministers.

Polls show the outcome is finely balanced. But a scandal that broke on Wednesday might tip the scales against the prime minister. A junior justice minister from Ms Meloni’s party was shown to have entered a mysterious business arrangement with the teenage daughter of a man jailed for helping organised crime. For Ms Meloni, the timing could not have been worse.

Photograph: Ju Huanzong/Xinhua/eyevine

Keely Hodgkinson’s golden opportunity

Some athletes are so good that they are competing not primarily with their rivals but with the limits of the human body. Mondo Duplantis, a Swedish pole vaulter, is one of those. A British 800m runner, Keely Hodgkinson, is emerging as another. She is all but certain to win gold at the World Athletics Indoor Championships in Poland on Sunday. She will also aim to beat her own world indoor record of 1 minute 54.87 seconds, which she set last month.

Ms Hodgkinson also has the outdoor record in her sights, which was set back in 1983 by Jarmila Kratochvilova, a Czechoslovak athlete. That is one of several long-standing women’s world records with an asterisk next to it because of suspicions (if unproven) of doping. No athlete has come close to Ms Kratochvilova’s mark; Ms Hodgkinson’s personal best is still more than a second slower. But in the long run, she has a real chance of becoming the world’s greatest-ever female 800m runner.

Photograph: Alamy

A cinematic hail mary?

The sun is dimming. A star-eating microbe is gobbling up solar energy, causing the Earth's temperature to plummet. Who can prevent the next ice age? Meet Ryland Grace, a zany science teacher who is sent on a one-way mission to investigate the interstellar parasite. Along with an alien who resembles a rock, whom he dubs Rocky, Ryland embarks on a rollicking mission to save the world.

"Project Hail Mary", released in cinemas this week, is both a science-fiction adventure and a buddy comedy. It stands out for its excellent cinematography and droll script, as well as Ryan Gosling's brilliant performance as Ryland. The film's true mission is to become a box-office hit for Amazon MGM, which splurged $200m on it. There are signs that the movie could become the studio's first original blockbuster: 95% of critics so far have given it a positive review, according to Rotten Tomatoes, an aggregator site. Executives will hope filmgoers are just as enthusiastic.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Bill Greggs, Birmingham, England

Eli Powell, Roswell, Georgia, America

Linda Bonger, Zurich, Switzerland

They all gave the correct answers of: Ripley; The Hunting of the Snark; Ryan Gosling; Ultimatum; Martian Chronicles

The theme is movies starring Matt Damon: "The Talented Mr Ripley"; "Good Will Hunting", "Saving Private Ryan"; "The Bourne Ultimatum"; "The Martian".

The questions were:

Monday: Which character is portrayed by Sigourney Weaver in the Alien films?

Tuesday: The Bellman is a key character in which Lewis Carroll poem?

Wednesday: Which actor played Ken in the Barbie live action movie?

Thursday: What word is used for a demand that must be met within a set period of time?

Friday: Which 1950 novel by Ray Bradbury is set on another planet?

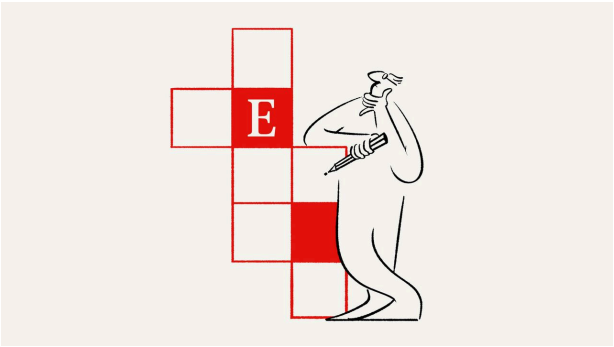

Illustration: The Economist

Crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it here. Or, if you prefer, use the grid below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Office manager is kind of crude (5)

2 across - Academia might contain somewhere sunny (5)

3 across - Swiftian human search engine (5)

1 down - London neighbourhood flowers into ruby arrangement (10)

Straight clues

1 across - An oilfield in the North Sea that gives its name to an oil-price benchmark (5)

2 across - Big city in southern Florida (5)

3 across - What Jonathan Swift called “a brute in human form” (5)

1 down - The London neighbourhood from which a set of modernist writers took their name (10)

If you don’t like someone’s story, write your own.

Chinua Achebe